

Game 162 -> Wild Card Resource Optimization

Qualification Probability, Ace Preservation, and the Zack Wheeler Decision State

DATE	September 27, 2026
ANALYSIS LOCK	12:44 PM ET / 16:44 UTC
DOCUMENT STATUS	AUDITED PRE-GAME ANALYSIS
AUDIT DISPOSITION	PASS WITH MATERIAL QUANTITATIVE REPAIR
CONTROLLING RECORD	Game 162 Qualification x Resource-Preservation Scan + subsequent audit

CORE FINDING

The resource-preservation conflict survives audit. Exact exchange-rate calibration does not. A postseason berth is not a single terminal state when the resource used to obtain it changes the next elimination series.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The optimization problem is real; the optimal answer is not yet calibrated.

Philadelphia's final regular-season decision is not adequately described by a binary IN / OUT state. The club can qualify by winning its own game or by losing while Arizona also loses. That external escape hatch reduces the marginal qualification value of any resource devoted only to improving Philadelphia's Game 162 win probability.^[1]

IMMEDIATE OBJECTIVE

P(QUALIFY)

Using Wheeler increases Philadelphia's chance to win Game 162. Because Arizona can also lose, not every additional point of PHI win probability becomes a full point of qualification probability.

DOWNSTREAM OBJECTIVE

P(ADVANCE)

A full Sunday Wheeler start compresses his rest window before a Tuesday-Wednesday-Thursday Wild Card Series. Preserving him keeps the Game 1 ace option available.^{[3][4]}

AUDITED STRUCTURAL FINDING

A strategy that maximizes qualification probability does not necessarily maximize championship probability.

The objective functions can conflict. The current evidence does not establish that they conflict enough to reverse the preferred Game 162 decision.

The original sensitivity model assigned bounded game-level probabilities to Wheeler/Sale, Sanchez/Mahle, and replacement/Holmes matchups. Those assumptions were not generated by a validated predictive model. The arithmetic downstream of the assumptions is reproducible; the assumptions themselves are not empirical facts.

The audit therefore downgrades the headline numerical exchange rate. Wheeler's Wild Card value is directionally positive and plausibly material, but the estimated 4-8 percentage-point range is **ILLUSTRATIVE SENSITIVITY**, not a calibrated forecast.

PURE CHAMPIONSHIP OPTIMIZATION
UNRESOLVED

STRUCTURAL OPTIMIZATION
CONFLICT
CONFIRMED

EXACT EXCHANGE RATE
UNRESOLVED

The largest rotation uncertainty is Jesus Luzardo. Philadelphia has kept both starting and relief roles open; subsequent pregame reporting documented a successful bullpen session, but did not establish conventional starter capacity for the Wild Card Series.^{[9][10]} San Diego's later personnel decision also matters: preserving high-leverage relievers weakens Philadelphia's external escape hatch and thereby increases Wheeler's marginal qualification value, without establishing a precise Arizona win probability.^[11]

READER RULE

Do not read the illustrative 24.7% vs. 27.2% NLDS-reach calculation as a managerial recommendation. Read it as proof that the decision has a genuine intertemporal resource-allocation dimension worth modeling.

1 - ORIGINAL PROBLEM

Qualification has two paths, so the value of today's ace is discounted by the escape hatch.

At the locked pregame state, Philadelphia could secure the final National League Wild Card berth by winning against Tampa Bay or by receiving an Arizona loss at San Diego. Arizona held the tiebreaker, so the only elimination branch was a Philadelphia loss combined with an Arizona win.^[1]

$$P(Q) = P(\text{PHI win}) + P(\text{PHI loss}) \times P(\text{ARI loss})$$

Under a pregame independence approximation:

$$P(Q) = 1 - P(\text{ARI win}) \times [1 - P(\text{PHI win})]$$

ESCAPE-HATCH CONSEQUENCE

Philadelphia does not require its own victory in every qualification branch. Therefore, a resource that improves only Philadelphia's Game 162 win probability does not translate one-for-one into qualification probability.

Three nested objective functions

OBJECTIVE	FORMAL TARGET	DECISION IMPLICATION
1. Qualify	P(QUALIFY)	Prioritizes immediate survival of Game 162.
2. Qualify strong	P(QUALIFY AND ENTER WC WITH STRONG ROTATION)	Values the condition of the roster at the next gate.
3. Win title	P(WIN WORLD SERIES)	Values all downstream rounds, not just the immediate gate.

These objectives can produce different optimal resource decisions. This report does **not** establish that they actually reverse the preferred decision in Game 162. It establishes that the possibility is structurally legitimate and cannot be resolved by the qualification percentage alone.

| A green "CLINCHED" indicator does not mean two outcomes were equivalent.

Evidence discipline

SOURCE-DERIVED

Schedule, eligibility, announced rotation plans, injury updates, official game-time action.

CALCULATED

Algebraic transformations and arithmetic that follow from stated inputs.

ILLUSTRATIVE

Sensitivity values built from assumed game probabilities. Useful for structure, not calibrated forecasting.

2 - TERMINAL STATES + RESOURCE CLOCK

"IN" splits into materially different postseason states.

Q1 IN + WHEELER PRESERVED
Highest postseason resource

Q2 IN + PARTIAL CONSUMPTION
Value depends on actual value

Q3 IN + WHEELER CONSUMED
Immediate success, downstream

Q4 OUT + UNAVAILABLE
Season

Q5 OUT + SCHEDULED
Season

Current-season competitive utility

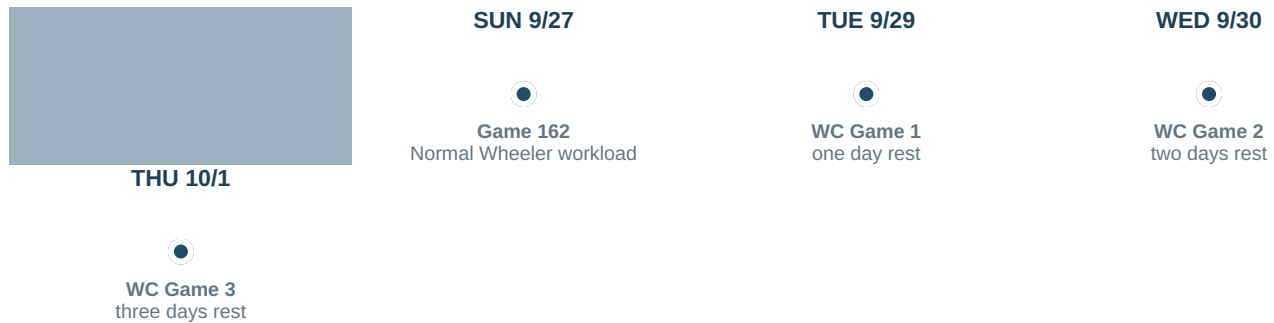
Q1 > Q2 > Q3 >>> Q4 ~ Q5

The same green CLINCHED label can hide materially different downstream resource states.

Figure 1. Terminal-state model. Q1 and Q3 both satisfy the immediate qualification gate, but they carry different Wild Card resources.

Wheeler resource clock

The Wild Card Series is scheduled for Tuesday, Sept. 29; Wednesday, Sept. 30; and, if necessary, Thursday, Oct. 1. The higher seed hosts all three games.^[3] Atlanta is the No. 3 seed and is positioned to host the No. 6 seed.^[7]



NORMAL SUNDAY WORKLOAD

- Game 1:** effectively unavailable as a conventional start.
- Game 2:** effectively unavailable as a conventional start.
- Game 3:** potential short-rest decision, not guaranteed.

WHEELER PRESERVED SUNDAY

- Game 1:** normal-rest availability preserved.
- Game 2/3:** downstream deployment remains flexible if Game 1 workload allows.

The Skubal 2025 example is used only as supporting schedule logic: MLB noted that a Sunday start would have left him a possible Thursday Game 3 option on short rest. It does not establish Wheeler's individual medical availability.^[6]

3 - ROTATION ARCHITECTURE

The downstream cost depends less on a label than on who can replace the innings.

Atlanta's reported Wild Card structure is unusually clear: Chris Sale for Game 1, Tyler Mahle for Game 2, and Grant Holmes for Game 3 if necessary.^[7] Philadelphia's architecture is conditional on whether Wheeler is consumed and on Luzardo's actual postseason capacity.

BRANCH A - WHEELER PRESERVED	
Game 1	Wheeler
Game 2	Cristopher Sanchez
Game 3	Nola / Painter / Luzardo-dependent alternative
Plausible architecture, not an official club plan.	

BRANCH B - WHEELER CONSUMED	
Game 1	Nola / Painter / Luzardo-dependent alternative
Game 2	Sanchez
Game 3	Replacement option or Wheeler on short rest if deemed available
Plausible architecture, not an official club plan.	

Sanchez worked seven innings Friday, making Wednesday the clean normal-rest slot in the supplied architecture.^[8] Aaron Nola was moved up to start Saturday on two days' rest, which complicates treating him as a simple fresh replacement for Tuesday.^[4]

Luzardo sensitivity

STATE	OPERATIONAL INTERPRETATION	EFFECT ON WHEELER MARGINAL VALUE
L0	Unavailable	Likely greatest Wheeler dependence.
L1	Relief / short workload only	Wheeler loss remains large because starting innings are not replaced.
L2	Meaningful abbreviated start	Some of Wheeler's missing innings can be absorbed.
L3	Conventional postseason start	Wheeler's marginal loss decreases.

Delta_WC(L) = WC(Wheeler available, L) - WC(Wheeler unavailable, L)

CURRENT AUDITED STATE
POSTSEASON ROLE POSSIBLE; STARTER CAPACITY UNRESOLVED. MLB reported that both starting and relief roles remained possible. A later pregame update documented a successful bullpen session, but did not establish that Luzardo could provide a normal postseason start.^{[9][10]}

4 - WHEELER QUALIFICATION VALUE

The more likely Arizona is to win, the more valuable Wheeler becomes today.

Let **p** equal Philadelphia's Game 162 win probability and **q** equal Arizona's Game 162 win probability. Under the independence approximation:

$$P(Q) = 1 - q(1 - p)$$

Differentiating with respect to Philadelphia's win probability:

$$\partial P(Q) / \partial p = q$$

Therefore, for a change in Philadelphia's win probability:

$$\text{Delta } P(Q) = P(\text{ARI win}) \times \text{Delta } P(\text{PHI win})$$

FORMAL IMPLICATION

If San Diego's personnel conservation makes an Arizona win more likely, two things happen simultaneously: Philadelphia's external escape hatch weakens, and Wheeler's marginal value to qualification increases.

Qualification value of an 8-point PHI win boost

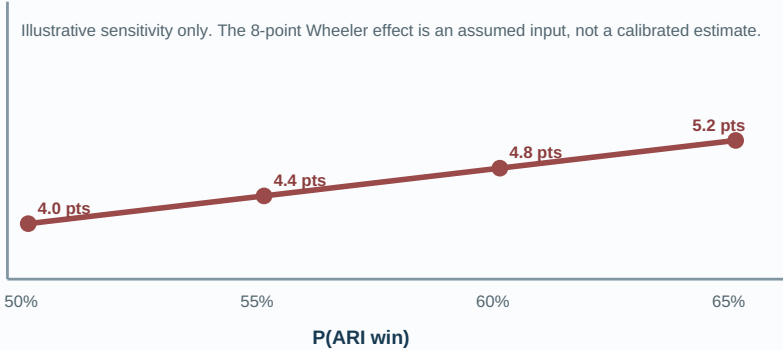


Figure 2. Qualification sensitivity if Wheeler is assumed to add eight percentage points to Philadelphia's Game 162 win probability. The eight-point input is illustrative, not calibrated.

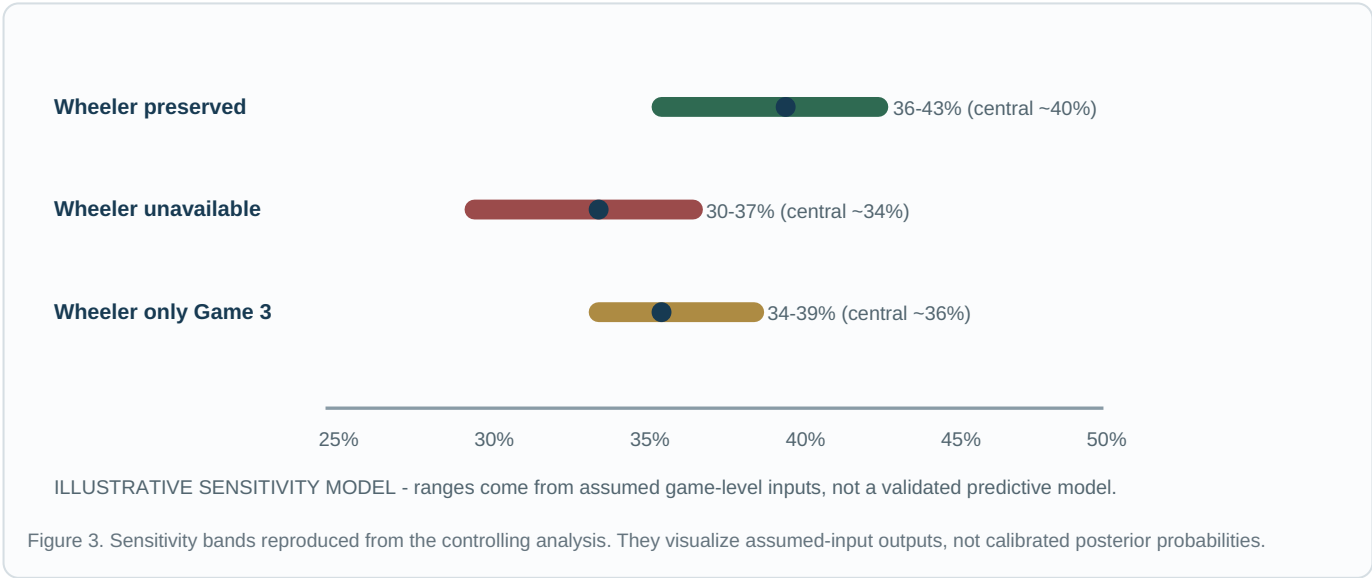
P(ARI WIN)	ASSUMED DELTA P(PHI WIN)	CALCULATED DELTA P(Q)	EVIDENCE STATUS
50%	+8.0 pts	+4.0 pts	ILLUSTRATIVE
55%	+8.0 pts	+4.4 pts	ILLUSTRATIVE
60%	+8.0 pts	+4.8 pts	ILLUSTRATIVE
65%	+8.0 pts	+5.2 pts	ILLUSTRATIVE

5 - WILD CARD SENSITIVITY MODEL

The original 4-8 point Wheeler range survives only as an illustrative sensitivity band.

The original scan assigned bounded game-level probabilities to a preserved-Wheeler architecture and a consumed-Wheeler architecture. The audit found no validated predictive model behind those inputs. The proper use is therefore sensitivity analysis.

WHEELER PRESERVED - ASSUMED GAME INPUTS	WHEELER UNAVAILABLE - ASSUMED GAME INPUTS
G1 Wheeler vs. Sale40-44%	G1 replacement vs. Sale27-33%
G2 Sanchez vs. Mahle46-50%	G2 Sanchez vs. Mahle46-50%
G3 alternative vs. Holmes36-42%	G3 replacement vs. Holmes35-41%
Illustrative series survival: ~36-43% Central sensitivity example: ~40%	Illustrative series survival: ~30-37% Central sensitivity example: ~34%



CALIBRATION WARNING
THIS IS NOT A CALIBRATED FORECAST. The arithmetic is reproducible. The game-level inputs are bounded analytical assumptions rather than probabilities generated by a validated predictive model.

DIRECTION Clearly positive	MAGNITUDE Potentially material / large	CALIBRATION UNRESOLVED
-------------------------------	---	---------------------------

Illustrative Delta_WC: approximately 4-8 percentage points, with a central sensitivity example near six points. That language replaces the stronger and unsupported statement that Wheeler "is worth" six points.

6 - GAME 1 + CHAMPIONSHIP-PATH CONFLICT

Game 1 matters, but its historical importance must not be counted twice.

MLB has reported that the Game 1 winner took more than 5,500 ordinary three-game series about 76% of the time.^[12] In the current best-of-three Wild Card format, Game 1 winners were 18-2 through the first two games of the 2025 round.^[13]

NO DOUBLE COUNTING

Those statistics are descriptive context. If Game 1 win probability is already embedded in a best-of-three probability tree, the historical Game 1-to-series relationship should not be layered on as an additional adjustment. Doing so would count the same structural advantage twice.

Illustrative championship-path conflict

BURN WHEELER

72.5% ILLUSTRATIVE QUALIFICATION

34% ILLUSTRATIVE WC SURVIVAL

$0.725 \times 0.34 = 24.7\%$

Illustrative probability of reaching the NLDS.

PRESERVE WHEELER

68.1% ILLUSTRATIVE QUALIFICATION

40% ILLUSTRATIVE WC SURVIVAL

$0.681 \times 0.40 = 27.2\%$

Illustrative probability of reaching the NLDS.

Illustrative difference: +2.5 percentage points toward preservation

CRITICAL AUDIT CONCLUSION

THIS DOES NOT ESTABLISH THAT PRESERVING WHEELER IS OPTIMAL. The estimated 2.5-point difference is smaller than the uncertainty surrounding several component probabilities, including the counterfactual Philadelphia win probability without Wheeler and Luzardo's usable postseason workload.

PURE CHAMPIONSHIP OPTIMIZATION
UNRESOLVED

WHAT THE EXAMPLE PROVES
OBJECTIVES CAN CONFLICT

MANAGERIAL RECOMMENDATION
NOT SUPPORTED

7 - EXTERNAL RESOURCE STATE + INFORMATION ORDERING

San Diego's conservation raises Wheeler's immediate value; the earlier Philadelphia start reduces information value.

SUBSEQUENT AUDIT UPDATE

San Diego announced a rest-altered Game 162 plan: Randy Vasquez was expected to open a bullpen-style game and the Padres planned to avoid high-leverage relievers.^[11] This is a **source-derived personnel/resource signal**, not a calibrated Arizona win probability.

Second-order effect

ESCAPE HATCH

A weaker San Diego deployment lowers the quality of Philadelphia's external rescue branch: PHI loss + ARI loss.

WHEELER QUALIFICATION VALUE

Because $\Delta P(Q) = P(\text{ARI win}) \times \Delta P(\text{PHI win})$, a higher Arizona win probability raises Wheeler's marginal qualification value.

Weather and information ordering

Philadelphia moved first pitch from 3:05 p.m. to 2:30 p.m. because of the weather forecast.^[2] Arizona-San Diego remained scheduled for 3:10 p.m.^[11] Absent another delay, Philadelphia therefore commits Wheeler before meaningful Arizona game information can accumulate.

PHI DELAY FROM 2:30	APPROXIMATE ARIZONA INFORMATION STATE	RESOURCE-INFORMATION VALUE
0 min	ARI game not started	None
30 min	Games nearly synchronized	Low
60-90 min	Early / middle ARI game	Low to moderate
~2 hours	Potentially meaningful ARI state	Moderate to high
ARI final first	Qualification external result known	Dispositive

DI WEATHER DISCIPLINE

Forecast, observation, official action, and DI² inference remain separate. A hypothetical long delay is a scenario, not an expected event. A midgame Arizona lead is information, not a clinching result.

The 2:30 move is documented here because it changes information ordering. This report does not attempt to reproduce the full weather forecast.

8 - EX-POST REDUNDANT RESOURCE EXPENDITURE

The "knife" branch is a hindsight state, not proof of a bad ex-ante decision.

Under the central illustrative assumptions in the controlling scan:

$$P(\text{PHI loss}) = 50\%$$

$$P(\text{ARI loss}) = 45\%$$

$$0.50 \times 0.45 = 22.5\%$$

That 22.5% branch is the state in which Wheeler is fully consumed, Philadelphia loses, Arizona loses, and Philadelphia qualifies through the external escape hatch anyway.

CORRECT TERMINOLOGY

EX-POST REDUNDANT RESOURCE EXPENDITURE BRANCH. The expenditure was not necessarily unnecessary when made. Arizona's result was unknown. It appears redundant with respect to qualification only after the external result resolves.

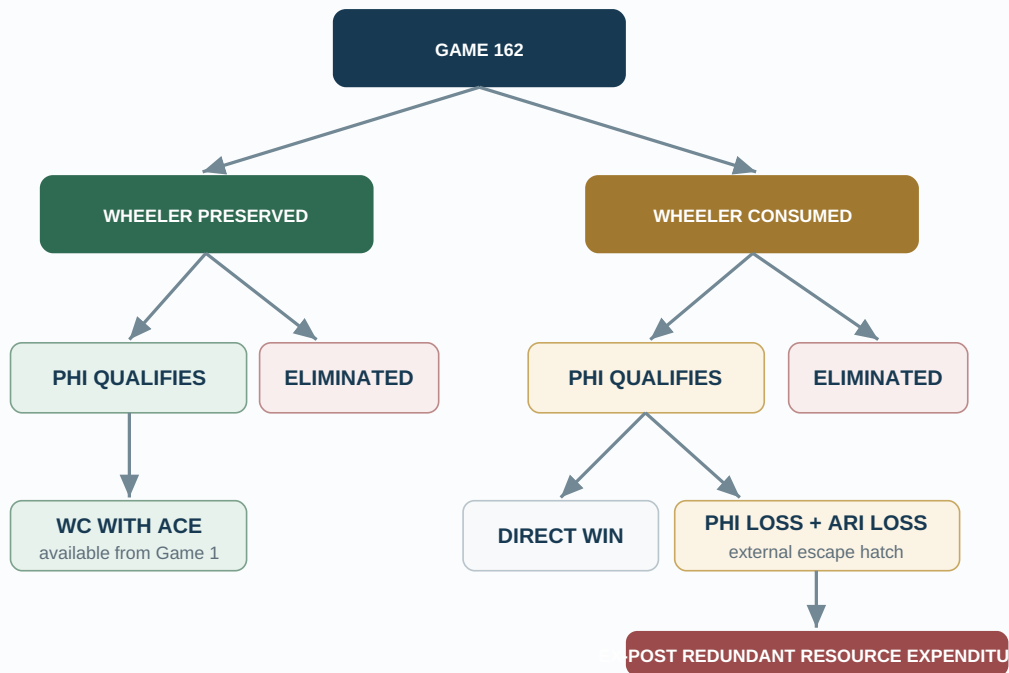


Figure 4. Resource state propagates beyond Game 162. The direct-win branch and the external-escape branch can both reach the Wild Card, but not with equivalent pitching resources.

EX-ANTE DECISION QUALITY

Evaluated using the information available before or at the moment of resource commitment.

EX-POST OUTCOME REDUNDANCY

Evaluated only after the external Arizona result is known. Hindsight can identify redundancy without proving the original decision was irrational.

9 - JOINT VALUE MODEL

Immediate gate value and downstream resource value can point in opposite directions.

WILD CARD RESOURCE VALUE ^

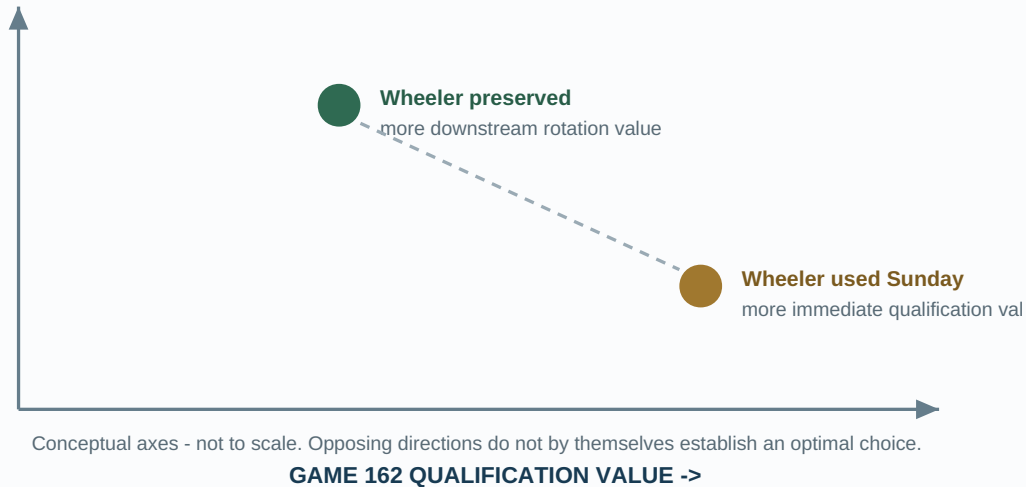


Figure 5. Conceptual two-axis value map. The plot is not an empirical scatterplot and is not to scale; it shows the direction of the tradeoff identified in the audit.

WHEELER USED SUNDAY

Immediate effect: raises Philadelphia's Game 162 win probability and therefore its qualification probability.
Downstream effect: compresses Wild Card rest and likely removes the normal Game 1/2 start options.

WHEELER PRESERVED

Immediate effect: lowers Philadelphia's own-game strength relative to using him.
Downstream effect: preserves a normal-rest Game 1 ace option if Philadelphia qualifies.

Terminal-state interpretation

Q1 - IN + ACE PRESERVED

Highest immediate-plus-downstream baseball value in the defined state set.

Q2 - IN + PARTIALLY CONSUMED

Value depends on actual workload and recovery implications.

Q3 - IN + ACE CONSUMED

Qualification achieved with a material constraint on the next series.

Q4 - OUT + CONSUMED

Season ends.

Q5 - OUT + PRESERVED

Season also ends; for current-season competitive utility, Q4 and Q5 are approximately equivalent.

RESOURCE RULE

Never evaluate a decision only by whether the immediate gate was passed. Track what had to be consumed to pass it.

10 - EVIDENCE AUDIT

Every important claim receives an evidence class and a limitation.

CLAIM	EVIDENCE CLASS	STATUS	LIMITATION
Qualification state machine	SOURCE-DERIVED	PASS	Final-day standings and tiebreaker support win-or-ARI-loss qualification path.
Game times	SOURCE-DERIVED	PASS WITH QUALIFICATION	2:30 PHI move is confirmed by subsequent audit source; Arizona remained 3:10.
Wheeler rest schedule	SOURCE-DERIVED + CALCULATED	PASS	Wild Card dates are official; rest-day implications are calendar arithmetic. Individual medical availability is not assumed.
Atlanta rotation	SOURCE-DERIVED	PASS	MLB FAQ lists Sale, Mahle, Holmes.
Luzardo status	SOURCE-DERIVED	PASS WITH QUALIFICATION	Postseason role possible; conventional starter capacity unresolved.
San Diego personnel conservation	SOURCE-DERIVED	PASS	Secondary reporting supports bullpen/resource conservation; used directionally only.
Arizona probability estimate	DI2 INFERENCE	UNRESOLVED	Direction can be updated; exact probability is not established by personnel news alone.
Philadelphia probability estimate	DI2 INFERENCE	UNRESOLVED	No validated counterfactual Game 162 model is supplied.
Wheeler Game 162 marginal value	ILLUSTRATIVE SENSITIVITY	ILLUSTRATIVE	Depends on assumed PHI win-probability delta.
WC preserved model	ILLUSTRATIVE SENSITIVITY	ILLUSTRATIVE	Game-level probabilities are bounded assumptions.
WC consumed model	ILLUSTRATIVE SENSITIVITY	ILLUSTRATIVE	Same limitation.
Wheeler Delta_WC	ILLUSTRATIVE SENSITIVITY	UNRESOLVED	4-8 points is a sensitivity range, not a calibrated finding.
22.5% redundant-resource branch	CALCULATED FROM ILLUSTRATIVE INPUTS	ILLUSTRATIVE	Arithmetic correct given 50% PHI loss and 45% ARI loss assumptions.
Pure championship optimization	JOINT INFERENCE	UNRESOLVED	Illustrative 2.5-point edge is smaller than component uncertainty.

AUDIT RULE

A reproducible calculation does not make its input assumptions empirical facts.

"PASS WITH QUALIFICATION" means the core factual proposition is supported but the downstream interpretation requires a boundary. "ILLUSTRATIVE" means arithmetic is useful for sensitivity analysis but should not be presented as a calibrated forecast.

11 - FINAL AUDITED FINDINGS

What is established, derived, illustrative, and not established.

ESTABLISHED

1. Philadelphia can qualify without winning its own game.^[1]
2. A normal Wheeler start Sunday materially changes his Wild Card availability because the series begins Tuesday and runs on three consecutive days.^{[3][4]}
3. Therefore qualification state and postseason-resource state are distinct.
4. San Diego's personnel conservation weakens Philadelphia's external escape hatch as a directional resource signal.^[11]
5. Luzardo's postseason starter capacity remains a major unresolved variable.^{[9][10]}

DERIVED

6. Wheeler's qualification value increases as Arizona's win probability increases:

$$\Delta P(Q) = P(\text{ARI win}) \times \Delta P(\text{PHI win})$$

ILLUSTRATIVE

1. Current sensitivity assumptions produce approximately +4 points of qualification value from Wheeler versus approximately +6 points of conditional Wild Card value if preserved.
2. The illustrative combined model produces approximately 24.7% versus 27.2% probability of reaching the NLDS.

NOT ESTABLISHED

1. That preserving Wheeler maximizes World Series probability.
2. That Wheeler's actual Wild Card value is exactly six percentage points.

PURE CHAMPIONSHIP OPTIMIZATION
UNRESOLVED

STRUCTURAL OPTIMIZATION
CONFLICT
CONFIRMED

EXACT EXCHANGE RATE
UNRESOLVED

Methodology note

The supplied Game 162 Qualification x Resource-Preservation Scan and its subsequent audit are the controlling analytical record. The audit supersedes the original scan wherever they differ. External sources in the references substantiate source-derived premises and later-recovered audit updates; they do not silently overwrite the 12:44 PM ET pregame lock. Calculated values are reproduced from stated formulas. DI² inferences are labeled as such. Sensitivity ranges retain the original model's assumptions but are explicitly downgraded from findings to illustrative inputs.

FINAL FINDING

Game 162 presents a genuine intertemporal optimization problem. Using Zack Wheeler can increase Philadelphia's probability of reaching the postseason while simultaneously reducing the strength of Philadelphia's first postseason series configuration. Whether that tradeoff ultimately favors using or preserving Wheeler under a pure championship-maximization objective remains unresolved.

12 - CLOSING RULES + SOURCES I

DI² closing rules

A green "CLINCHED" indicator does not mean two outcomes were equivalent.

Q1

IN + ACE PRESERVED

Q3

IN + ACE CONSUMED**SPORTSWISE RULE**

Causality over fan logic.

RESOURCE RULE

Never evaluate a decision only by whether the immediate gate was passed. Track what had to be consumed to pass it.

AUDIT RULE

A reproducible calculation does not make its input assumptions empirical facts.

Source notes

Sources are listed so the factual premises can be reproduced independently. Sources published or recovered after the 12:44 PM ET analysis lock are identified in their use notes as subsequent audit material rather than silently merged into the locked state.

[1] Yahoo Sports: Phillies enter final day of MLB regular season on verge of unfathomable choke in playoff race

2026-09-27

<https://sports.yahoo.com/mlb/article/phillies-enter-final-day-of-mlb-regular-season-on-verge-of-unfathomable-choke-in-playoff-race-035043266.html>

Use in report: Final-day standings, Arizona tiebreaker, and qualification path.

[2] CBS News Philadelphia: Philadelphia Phillies' final regular-season game moved up to 2:30 p.m.

2026-09-27

<https://www.cbsnews.com/philadelphia/news/phillies-game-time-weather-sunday/>

Use in report: Official-action confirmation that first pitch was moved from 3:05 p.m. to 2:30 p.m. because of the weather forecast. Published after the analysis lock; used as a subsequent audit source confirming the pregame action.

[3] MLB.com: 2026 MLB Playoff and World Series schedule

2026-08-10

<https://www.mlb.com/news/2026-mlb-playoff-and-world-series-schedule>

Use in report: Wild Card Games 1-3 on Sept. 29, Sept. 30, and Oct. 1; higher seed hosts all three games; NLDS begins Oct. 3.

[4] MLB.com: With playoff lives at stake, Phillies shuffle weekend rotation, lineup

2026-09-26

<https://www.mlb.com/news/aaron-nola-moved-up-to-start-saturday-for-phillies>

Use in report: Nola started Saturday on two days' rest; Phillies kept Wheeler scheduled for Sunday on normal rest.

[5] MLB.com: Wheeler achieves career, franchise milestones as Phils close in on Wild Card

2026-09-23

<https://www.mlb.com/news/zack-wheeler-reaches-2-000-career-strikeouts>

Use in report: Wheeler's Sept. 22 start and late-season performance context.

SOURCES II + PROVENANCE

Source notes, continued

[6] MLB.com: Tarik Skubal set to start Game 1 of AL Wild Card Series

2025-09

<https://www.mlb.com/amp/news/tarik-skubal-set-to-start-game-1-of-al-wild-card-series.html>

Use in report: Supporting precedent: a Sunday start would have left Skubal only a potential Thursday Game 3 appearance on short rest. Context only, not medical proof for Wheeler.

[7] MLB.com: Postseason FAQ: What's next for the Braves?

2026-09-27 access

<https://www.mlb.com/braves/news/braves-2026-postseason-faq>

Use in report: Atlanta as NL No. 3 host; reported Wild Card rotation Sale, Mahle, Holmes.

[8] MLB.com: Cristopher Sanchez's 10 strikeouts

2026-09-25

<https://www.mlb.com/phillies/video/cristopher-sanchez-s-10-strikeouts>

Use in report: Sanchez worked seven innings on Friday, relevant to Wednesday rest architecture.

[9] MLB.com: Luzardo (shoulder) plays catch; return to mound TBD

2026-09-22

<https://www.mlb.com/news/jesus-luzardo-plays-catch-managing-shoulder-injury>

Use in report: Phillies said both starting and relief roles remained possible in the Wild Card Series; mound-return timing remained unresolved at that point.

[10] MLB.com: Luzardo throws bullpen in massive step toward return to Phillies rotation

2026-09-24

<https://www.mlb.com/amp/news/jesus-luzardo-throws-bullpen-ahead-of-brewers-phillies-finale.html>

Use in report: Subsequent audit update within the pregame period: Luzardo completed an approximately 30-pitch bullpen and reported feeling normal; starter capacity still not established.

[11] Sports Illustrated - Padres On SI: Padres Announce Starting Pitcher, Lineup for Final Game of Regular Season vs Diamondbacks

2026-09-27

<https://www.si.com/mlb/padres/onsi/padres-announce-starting-pitcher-lineup-final-game-regular-season-diamondbacks>

Use in report: Subsequent audit update: Randy Vasquez expected to open a bullpen-style game and San Diego planned to avoid high-leverage relievers. Used as a personnel/resource signal, not a calibrated probability.

[12] MLB.com: How winning Game 1 affects teams' Wild Card Series odds

2020

<https://www.mlb.com/news/how-winning-game-1-affects-teams-wild-card-series-odds>

Use in report: Descriptive context: Game 1 winners took more than 5,500 ordinary three-game series about 76% of the time.

[13] MLB.com: Top storylines for a huge day of decisive Wild Card action

2025-10-02

<https://www.mlb.com/news/game-3-storylines-for-2025-wild-card-series>

Use in report: Descriptive context: through the first two games of the 2025 Wild Card round, Game 1 winners were 18-2 in the current best-of-three format.

Provenance and limitations

Controlling analytical record: the supplied Qualification x Resource-Preservation Scan and subsequent audit. **Historical lock:** Sept. 27, 2026 at 12:44 PM ET / 16:44 UTC. **Subsequent audit updates:** used only when explicitly labeled, principally to confirm the 2:30 game-time action and San Diego's personnel/resource deployment. **Probability limitation:** no validated predictive model was supplied for the counterfactual Philadelphia-without-Wheeler game or for the Wild Card matchup probabilities. Therefore all such values remain illustrative sensitivity inputs.

DOCUMENT DISPOSITION

PASS WITH MATERIAL QUANTITATIVE REPAIR. Core knife insight survives. Direction survives. Exact exchange rate does not yet pass DI².

Prepared as a standalone analytical report. No recommendation is made to Philadelphia management. The purpose is to preserve the distinction between immediate qualification and downstream roster state.

Game 162 - Second-Order Insights

Append-only analytical layer preserving the 11:50 locked scan

RECORD INTEGRITY

The original 11:50 scan remains unchanged. This document is an append-only DI² layer containing later second-order analysis.

Source posture: the substantive content below is based on the user-supplied scan text and is not silently reconciled against later information.

Central estimate carried into this layer

PHI WIN	~50%
ARI WIN	~52-53%
PHI POSTSEASON	~74%

The ~74% headline is a combined survival estimate, not a single-game win probability. The sections below preserve that distinction and track the causal structures that matter as first pitch approaches.

12. DI² SECOND-ORDER INSIGHTS

INSIGHT 1 - 74% IS NOT REALLY ONE PROBABILITY

Philadelphia has two independent survival mechanisms:

PATH A - PHILADELPHIA WINS	~50 percentage points
PATH B - PHILADELPHIA LOSES, BUT ARIZONA ALSO LOSES	~23.75 percentage points

Using the central estimates:

P(PHI loss) = 50%
P(ARI loss) = 47.5%
 $0.50 \times 0.475 = 23.75$ percentage points

Total: $50\% + 23.75\% = 73.75\%$

Approximately one-third of Philadelphia's survival probability therefore comes from San Diego rescuing Philadelphia after Philadelphia loses.

KEY DISTINCTION

Philadelphia is not a 74% favorite to win today's baseball game.

Philadelphia is approximately a coin flip in its own game with a substantial external escape hatch.

INSIGHT 2 - WHY THE PHILLIES COLLAPSE DOESN'T AUTOMATICALLY PRODUCE 67%

Holding Arizona's win probability at approximately 52.5%:

PHI win probability	PHI postseason probability
55%	76.4%
50%	73.8%
45%	71.1%
40%	68.5%
37%	66.9%
35%	65.9%

For Philadelphia's survival probability to fall to approximately 67%, while Arizona remains around 52-53%, Philadelphia's true probability of beating Tampa Bay would need to fall to roughly 37%.

That is a much stronger proposition than: **"The Phillies are playing badly."**

It effectively requires the evidence to support: **"Zack Wheeler at home against Tampa Bay is roughly a 37% proposition today."**

DI² CLASSIFICATION

67% HYPOTHESIS - possible under a harsh PHI game model, but not currently central.

INSIGHT 3 - WHEELER IS A FAILURE-SURFACE FIREWALL

Wheeler's value today is larger than the ordinary difference between one starting pitcher and another.

Philadelphia currently has at least two degraded subsystems: **OFFENSE** and **BULLPEN / PITCHING DEPTH**.

Wheeler can directly reduce Philadelphia's exposure to the second one.

Wheeler depth	Structural effect
7 innings	Bullpen weakness relatively contained
6 innings	Bullpen weakness becomes relevant
5 innings	Bullpen weakness becomes a major game-state variable

Wheeler does not merely improve expected run prevention. He determines how much of Philadelphia's currently degraded roster has to participate in the game.

DI² INTERPRETATION

WHEELER 7 IP -> failure surface isolated.

WHEELER 5 IP -> failure surface exposed.

This may be the single most important structural insight in the Philadelphia game.

INSIGHT 4 - PHILADELPHIA DOES NOT NEED ITS OFFENSE TO "RECOVER"

This is a threshold problem. Philadelphia's offense does not need to suddenly return to its season-long 4.39 runs/game identity.

It needs to produce enough runs to remain inside the Wheeler + late-relief run-prevention envelope.

CORRECT QUESTION

Not: "Has the Phillies offense recovered?"

Ask: "Can this lineup produce minimum viable offense before Wheeler's run-prevention advantage expires?"

If Wheeler allows two runs and Philadelphia wins 3-2, the offense may still be structurally impaired. But Game 162 does not care.

A three-run offense can be inadequate as a long-term postseason offense while being adequate for today's survival problem.

DI² VARIABLE: MINIMUM VIABLE OFFENSE THRESHOLD

INSIGHT 5 - THE WEATHER HAS THREE DIFFERENT EFFECTS, NOT ONE

"Bad weather" is too crude a variable. Today's environment creates three separate mechanisms.

State	Mechanism	Directional effect
A - Cool / windy / playable	Possible run suppression	Can reinforce a Wheeler-centered low-scoring game; potentially m
B - Intermittent rain with cut-in	Major interruption condition uncertain	Variance rises; directional advantage unclear.
C - Interruption-producing weather	Wheeler continuity becomes the issue	A long interruption after Wheeler begins could destroy one of Phila

Run-suppressing weather can help Wheeler while interruption-producing weather can hurt Wheeler. Those statements are not contradictory; they describe different physical mechanisms.

INSIGHT 6 - THE WORST WEATHER STATE MAY NOT BE THE WORST WEATHER

The most dangerous operational branch is arguably:

W2 -> W3 -> W4 -> INTERRUPTION

substantial warm-up -> Wheeler starts -> Wheeler accumulates meaningful workload -> game stops

Philadelphia can then pay warm-up cost + pitch cost + recovery cost without necessarily receiving completed game + postseason qualification + preserved postseason starter.

By comparison, an enormous delay before Wheeler meaningfully warms up may be operationally cleaner.

If that delay allows Arizona-San Diego to finish and Arizona loses, Philadelphia clinches without needing Wheeler for qualification.

DI² WEATHER CURVE

Playable -> acceptable

Short disruption -> annoying

Post-start long disruption -> potentially very bad

Extreme pregame delay -> potentially strategically useful

Weather harm is nonlinear. More rain does not mechanically equal worse outcome.

INSIGHT 7 - ARIZONA'S BULLPEN WEAKNESS IS CONDITIONAL ON SOROKA

Arizona's heavy Saturday bullpen expenditure does not automatically make Arizona substantially weaker today. It becomes important if San Diego can force Soroka out early enough to expose it.

San Diego's offensive objective therefore has two components:

- Score runs.
- Consume Soroka pitches.

An apparently uneventful Arizona-San Diego game can contain highly favorable information for Philadelphia.

Example A: ARI 1 - SD 1, bottom 4th; Soroka 82 pitches through 4 -> Arizona's stressed relief structure is approaching the game.

Example B: ARI 1 - SD 1; Soroka 48 pitches through 5 -> substantially better news for Arizona.

LIVE DI² RULE

Do not monitor only the Arizona score.

Monitor: SCORE + INNING + SOROKA PITCH COUNT + ARIZONA BULLPEN EXPOSURE.

INSIGHT 8 - THE TWO STARTING PITCHERS CREATE OPPOSITE DEPTH PROBLEMS

Philadelphia wants Wheeler to make the game shorter. Arizona wants Soroka to make the game shorter. The opponents want the reverse.

Tampa Bay benefits enormously from getting Wheeler to 90-100 pitches early. San Diego benefits enormously from getting Soroka to 80-90 pitches early.

Pitch efficiency may therefore be more predictive than early scoring in both games.

A 0-0 Philadelphia game after three innings is not necessarily excellent news if Wheeler required 65 pitches to get there. Likewise, a scoreless Arizona game is not necessarily bad news for Philadelphia if Soroka required 70 pitches.

SECONDARY LIVE STATE

OUTS PURCHASED PER PITCH

This tells us how quickly each game is approaching its weaker bullpen state.

INSIGHT 9 - THE PHILLIES' OFFENSE HAS A SPECIFIC FAILURE MODE TODAY

A weak offense is particularly dangerous in a low-scoring environment because each failed scoring opportunity becomes more valuable.

If weather suppresses total scoring and Wheeler performs well, one walk + one defensive mistake + one extra-base hit can become disproportionately important.

The recent offensive problem does not necessarily manifest as "they need to score six and can't." It can manifest as "they need to score three and strand the runner who would have scored the third."

Relevant offensive variables become concentrated around getting on base, avoiding empty strikeouts, converting limited scoring opportunities, and preventing innings from dying without advancing runners.

INSIGHT 10 - THE TWO GAMES ARE PROBABILISTICALLY INDEPENDENT, BUT OPERATIONALLY COUPLED

Before first pitch, treating PHI-TB and ARI-SD as approximately independent baseball outcomes is reasonable. But they are not operationally independent.

Information from San Diego can change Philadelphia's optimal resource decisions.

- ARI trails badly early: does not mathematically clinch anything, but can affect how aggressively Philadelphia wants to expend Wheeler or a stressed reliever in marginal situations.
- ARI wins: removes the escape hatch entirely. Philadelphia then knows its own game is dispositive.

DISTINCTION

PROBABILITY LAYER - games approximately independent.

DECISION LAYER - games causally coupled through information.

That distinction is exactly why synchronized start times matter.

INSIGHT 11 - THE VALUE OF INFORMATION CHANGES RAPIDLY AS FIRST PITCH APPROACHES

Another hundred historical Wheeler statistics probably changes the estimate very little. A confirmed lineup can. An official delay can. A scratched player can. A Padres rest decision can. A bullpen availability announcement can.

Optimal evidence-retrieval order:

1. Confirmed PHI lineup
2. Confirmed TB lineup
3. Confirmed SD lineup
4. Confirmed ARI lineup
5. Official PHI game status
6. Current radar / observed precipitation
7. Bullpen availability changes

DI² CLASSIFICATION

The system has moved from MODEL BUILDING to HIGH-VALUE STATE CHANGE DETECTION.

INSIGHT 12 - 74% HAS TWO VERY DIFFERENT TYPES OF UNCERTAINTY

The ~70-78% range should not be interpreted as ordinary statistical error alone.

Epistemic Uncertainty	Aleatory Uncertainty
Things not yet known: confirmed lineups; reliever availability; weather; etc.	Things that are known but cannot be predicted: pitcher's health; umpire's call; etc.

DI² can reduce the first category as information arrives. It cannot eliminate the second. Even a perfect pregame information state would not transform today's problem into deterministic baseball.

INSIGHT 13 - THE 74% NUMBER SHOULD MOVE ASYMMETRICALLY WITH NEW INFORMATION

- Because Philadelphia has two qualification paths, new information does not affect survival symmetrically.
- A Phillies lineup downgrade hurts only the PHI-win branch.
 - A Padres lineup downgrade hurts only the ARI-loss escape branch.
 - Philadelphia lineup weakened + San Diego heavily rests starters can simultaneously reduce Philadelphia's direct path and weaken its backup path.
 - Full Phillies lineup + weak Tampa lineup + full-strength Padres lineup can move the estimate upward through both branches.

DI² RULE

The most important updates are not necessarily the largest individual updates.

They are updates that damage or strengthen both survival engines simultaneously.

INSIGHT 14 - THERE IS A HIDDEN "ESCAPE-HATCH QUALITY" METRIC

Define:

ESCAPE-HATCH QUALITY
P(SD defeats ARI | current personnel and game state)

At the current central estimate, escape-hatch quality is approximately 47-48%. Philadelphia's fallback mechanism is therefore currently almost a coin flip.

- If San Diego's lineup is badly degraded, escape-hatch quality falls.
- If Soroka struggles early, it rises.
- If Arizona takes a large lead, it collapses.
- If San Diego takes a large lead and forces Soroka out, it can rise dramatically.

SPORTSWISE LIVE DISPLAY

PHI DIRECT PATH: current PHI game state

PHI ESCAPE PATH: current SD-over-ARI state

OVERALL SURVIVAL: combined state

This is cleaner than staring at two scoreboards and emotionally improvising.

INSIGHT 15 - THE MOST IMPORTANT LIVE THRESHOLDS ARE NOW IDENTIFIABLE

Once play begins, watch these rather than generic "momentum":

PHILADELPHIA	ARIZONA / SD	WEATHER
Wheeler pitch count through 3	Soroka pitch count through 3	Observed precipitation
Wheeler pitch count through 5	Soroka pitch count through 5	Official delay status
TB times through order	Score when Soroka exits	Whether Wheeler has begun substantial warm-up

PHI baserunners / scoring opportunities	Arizona bullpen innings required	Whether interruption occurs before or after W3
Runs banked before Wheeler exits	Which Arizona relievers are actually available	
Number of bullpen outs required		

Those variables have direct causal paths to the outcome. "Philadelphia looks nervous" does not.

13. DI² CAUSAL GRAPH

The Game 162 problem can be represented compactly as two linked survival engines.

Input	Mechanism	Output
PHILLIES OFFENSE	minimum viable runs	PHI GAME STATE
WHEELER QUALITY	innings completed -> bullpen outs required	PHI GAME STATE
WEATHER PHYSICS	run environment / variance	PHI GAME STATE
WEATHER TIMING	Wheeler preparation / interruption -> availability + workload	PHI GAME STATE / POSTSEASON RESOURCE S

Meanwhile:



14. DI² LIVE MONITORING BOARD

Once the games begin, replace the static ~74% report with a state monitor.

PHILADELPHIA DIRECT PATH
Score:
Inning:
Wheeler pitches:
Wheeler state: W3 / W4 / W5
Expected innings remaining:
Bullpen outs required:
PHI minimum viable offense status: NOT MET / APPROACHING / MET
PHILADELPHIA ESCAPE PATH
ARI-SD score:
Inning:
Soroka pitches:
Soroka still active: YES / NO
Arizona bullpen exposure: LOW / APPROACHING / ACTIVE
SD escape-hatch quality: IMPROVING / STABLE / DETERIORATING
WEATHER
Observed rain:
Official delay:
Radar trajectory:
Wheeler interruption risk:
Wheeler resource state:
COMBINED
DIRECT PATH: STRONG / NEUTRAL / WEAK / LOST
ESCAPE PATH: STRONG / NEUTRAL / WEAK / LOST
SURVIVAL STATE: COMFORTABLE / LIVE / DANGEROUS / CRITICAL / RESOLVED

UPDATE RULE

No probability should be updated merely because one team "looks better."

Every update must correspond to a changed causal input.

15. DI² PRE-GAME STRUCTURAL VERDICT

The approximately 74% survival estimate is best understood as two survival engines: roughly 50 percentage points from Philadelphia winning its own game and roughly 24 percentage points from San Diego rescuing Philadelphia after a loss.

Philadelphia's recent collapse matters, but Wheeler acts as a partial firewall because his ability to pitch deeply can prevent the stressed bullpen from becoming a major participant.

The offense therefore does not need to become good again; it needs to produce minimum viable offense before Wheeler's run-prevention envelope expires.

Weather has a nonlinear role: playable cold/wind may reinforce a low-scoring Wheeler game, while a post-start interruption could destroy that advantage, and an extreme pregame delay could paradoxically create useful Arizona information.

Arizona's bullpen weakness likewise becomes important only if San Diego forces Soroka to consume enough pitches to expose it.

The most valuable new evidence is therefore no longer another historical statistic. It is state change:

Lineups.

Pitch counts.

Bullpen exposure.

Observed weather.

Official delay decisions.

Runs actually banked.

DI² BOTTOM LINE

CURRENT SURVIVAL	~74%
DIRECT PHILADELPHIA ENGINE	~50 percentage points
SAN DIEGO ESCAPE ENGINE	~24 percentage points
PRIMARY PHI CONTROL VARIABLE	Wheeler depth + minimum viable offense
PRIMARY EXTERNAL VARIABLE	Soroka depth + San Diego's ability to expose Arizona's bullpen
PRIMARY WEATHER RISK	Wheeler begins and is then interrupted

PRIMARY WEATHER OPPORTUNITY	Sufficiently long pre-start delay changes the information order
67% FAILURE TEST	Requires substantially worse conditions than presently established
BIGGEST NEXT INFORMATION SHOCK	Confirmed lineups / official game-status change

SPORTSWISE RULE

Causality over fan logic.

DI WEATHER RULE

Forecast, observation, official decision, and later outcome remain separate records.

GAME 162 RULE

Do not ask whether Philadelphia is "choking." Ask:

How many runs has Philadelphia banked?

How many outs has Wheeler purchased?

How many bullpen outs remain?

How many pitches has Soroka spent?

And is San Diego still capable of saving everybody from themselves?